by the then Chief Justice Shri Ranjan Gogoi, and referred to a larger nine-Judge Bench. Pending the outcome in the proceedings before the nine-Judge Bench (known as a ‘Reference’, when a larger Bench is called upon to decide on questions of constitutional import), the next Chief Justice, Shri Sharad Arvind Bobde, declined to grant security to any woman of the reproductive age group who sought entry against the temple’s religious practices and beliefs, thereby restoring the status as it existed prior to the first verdict.[10]

Alongside this, in the first half of 2019, in relation to the Shri Padmanabhaswamy Temple in Kerala, I had the privilege of representing the Chief Tantri of the Temple, the Chief Priest of the Chilkur Balaji Temple in Hyderabad and People for Dharma before the Supreme Court in an appeal from the 2011 judgment of the Kerala High Court. In its judgment, the High Court had held that the Travancore Royal Family had no authority over the administration of the Padmanabhaswamy Temple after the abolition of royal titles and privileges by the Constitution (Twenty-Sixth Amendment) Act of 1971. The High Court had also transferred control over the Temple to a trust, which was to be managed by the appointees of the State Government of Kerala. Fortunately, the Supreme Court reversed the verdict of the High Court on 13 July 2020, and upheld the rights of the Travancore Royal Family as well as the authority of the Chief Tantri on religious matters in relation to the temple.[11] My involvement in this case required me to understand, among other things:

1. the nature of Hindu princely States prior to their integration with the Indian Union;
2. the relationship between the heads of Hindu princely States and their titular deities;
3. the circumstances, terms and conditions of integration of Hindu princely States with the Union;
4. the history surrounding the Twenty-Sixth Amendment to the Constitution; and
5. of course, the recurring issue of State control of temples.

Little did I know then that the experience of working on such matters of constitutional and civilisational significance would prepare me better to